

CASE BRIEF — THE CORMSIL COMPACT

Region: Yorkshire Dales, England → Oxford → London

Case Duration: 10 days (columns 10 → 1)

Threat: The Dōmere — Tier 2 Subterranean Presence (Threatening)

Sessions: 2-4

Era: 1987

MYSTERY STATEMENT

"A Tier 2 subterranean presence — the Dōmere, a pre-Celtic spirit that embodies the wrongfully dead and sends them back to torment the living — has awakened beneath a Yorkshire farming town after the 1882 compact that kept it asleep burned in a library fire, and the agents must piece together the spirit's identity from scattered texts, locate a hidden Victorian field manual, and either negotiate a new compact or perform a silencing ritual before the spirit expands its reach beyond Cormsil."

THE REAL STORY

What the Dōmere Is

A pre-Celtic presence in the earth beneath Cormsil. Named by the Saxons: "Dōmere" — the Doomer, the Judge. Predates human settlement in Britain. It was already in the earth when the first Celts arrived. The Brigantes tribe encountered it when they dug a ritual well that intersected its resting place. They learned its nature: it responds to wrongful death. It cannot abide an unbalanced ledger. The Celts incorporated it into their justice system — the worst criminals were brought to the well and made to confess. If their crimes were severe enough, the Dōmere would claim them.

The Romans tried to destroy it during their conquest of the Brigantes (70s CE) and failed — the Dōmere cannot be killed, only contained. The Saxons built a church over the well, then a town around the church. The compact of 1882 was the first successful negotiation — all previous attempts at binding (including Sir Geoffrey Colne's 1642 effort) failed because they treated the spirit as an enemy rather than a party to an agreement.

Function: When someone dies within the Dōmere's radius by neglect, violence, or preventable mistake, the spirit may embody the deceased with a fragment of itself. The returned person appears alive and healthy. They retain memories, personality, relationships — but they are compelled to make the responsible person *know* what they did. This compulsion escalates: first visits, then statements of "forgiveness," then constant presence, then psychological breaking. The returned are not ghosts. They are vessels. They eat, sleep, speak, continue their lives. They don't understand what they're doing. The spirit acts through them without their knowledge.

What Happened

Three weeks ago, the Cormsil library burned. Librarian Eleanor Vane fell asleep; a scented candle ignited a stack of books. Twenty-five people died — or should have. They were seen running into the woods behind the burning library. They emerged the next morning, unharmed, claiming no memory of the night. The town calls it a miracle.

But the 25 "survivors" are wrong. They blink too slowly (3–4 seconds between blinks). They're cold to the touch (~34°C). They finish each other's sentences. And every day, each of them visits Eleanor Vane to "forgive" her in voices that don't sound quite like their own. Eleanor hasn't slept since the fire.

The compact of 1882 — brokered by a mysterious organization known only as "The Society" — was stored in the library's "History of Cormsil" section. It burned in the fire. The spirit is awake. It found negligence (a librarian who fell asleep), preventable death (25 people), and no acknowledgment. It is furious. It sees humanity as morally corrupt — it's been asleep for 105 years and woke to a world where people let candles burn down libraries. It wants to expand. It wants every wrongful death everywhere to produce a returned.

Covenant Wayfinder detected an ancient, waking occult signature beneath Cormsil. Agents arrive to a town where nothing is obviously wrong and everything is subtly wrong.

RESOLUTION PATHS

Silence the Dömere

Use the Society's manual + Colne's manuscript (British Library) to perform a ritual that forces the spirit into permanent dormancy. Requires three components: (1) the spirit's true name — "Dömere" — spoken at the standing stone, (2) soil from the pre-Saxon resting site (a handful dug from beneath the standing stone), and (3) a volunteer among the returned who chooses true death over borrowed existence. The ritual forces the spirit into dormancy — not death, but sleep. The Compact is replaced by a binding. The remaining 24 returned collapse, unconscious, and wake as themselves — the spirit's fragments withdrawn. They remember everything. This is its own kind of horror: 24 people who know they died, know they tormented Eleanor Vane, know they were vessels for something ancient and merciless.

New Compact

Negotiate new terms with the Dömere using the Society's manual as framework. The spirit is angry and distrustful after 105 years of being forgotten. Its demands will be harsh — possibly requiring a living human witness to remain in Cormsil permanently, or a more binding form of acknowledgment that cannot be destroyed by a single fire. The spirit understands negotiation; it accepted the 1882 compact because The Society treated it as a party to an agreement rather than a monster to be slain.

Witness and Report

The agents fail to act. The Dömere expands. The returned phenomenon begins appearing in neighboring towns — every wrongful death in Yorkshire produces a returned within 48 hours. The Covenant files a containment failure. The Decay track advances by 1.

Catastrophe

The spirit fully manifests. Every wrongful death in Yorkshire produces a returned within 24 hours. Eleanor Vane dies — not from violence, but from exhaustion; her body simply stops. The returned lose their anchor. They become directionless, then hostile, acting on the spirit's sense of injustice without human context. The Decay

track advances by 3. Cormsil becomes a containment zone — 400 residents evacuated, 25 returned quarantined, the Dömere's radius expanding.

DA CHECKLIST — BEFORE SESSION 1

TASK	DONE
Print Operations Board + Organization Reference	☐
Print Location Pages L1-L7	☐
Print NPC Cards NPC1-NPC8	☐
Print and cut Information Cards I1-I22	☐
Print Relic Sheet	☐
Give players Case Brief — Player	☐
Start clock: Day 10, Morning	☐

KEY DRAMATIC BEATS

- Day 10-9:** Arrive in Cormsil. Interview the returned (evasive, slightly off), skeptical townsfolk (noticed the tells), Eleanor Vane (deteriorating). Visit the burned library — find remnants of the glass case and the compact's ash. Local historian identifies what was in the case.
- Day 8-7:** The church crypt. Find the Society's manual behind a loose stone — hidden by the vicar in 1882. The manual describes the Dömere and methods for negotiation/containment. References "Colne's manuscript" and "the vicar's papers at Oxford." Relic Milestone Day 7: the returned begin coordinating — they start visiting Eleanor in groups, speaking in unison.
- Day 6-5:** British Library, London. Sir Geoffrey Colne's 1642 manuscript *"Of Certain Subterranean Presences in the County of York"* — describes the Dömere, an earlier failed binding attempt, and the silencing ritual. Contains the Old English riddle encoding the spirit's true name. Bodleian Library, Oxford. The vicar's papers — includes summary of the 1882 compact terms, a letter to his bishop mentioning The Society, and a note about the hidden manual.
- Day 4-3:** Relic Milestone Day 4 — the spirit speaks. Agents and townsfolk hear a voice from beneath the earth: Old English, then Brythonic, then something older. It's reciting wrongs. Every preventable death in Cormsil's history. Return to Cormsil. Agents now have the true name (from the riddle), the ritual method (from Colne), and the negotiation framework (from the Society's manual). Find the pre-Saxon standing stone site (Dwerryhouse's field — the stone is warm).
- Day 2-1:** Attempt the silencing ritual at the standing stone, or negotiate a new compact. The spirit resists. The returned may intervene — they are extensions of the spirit and will protect it unless a volunteer breaks free. Relic Milestone Day 1 — the spirit attempts expansion beyond Cormsil.

RUNNING THE SILENCING RITUAL

The ritual requires three components. Missing any = automatic failure.

- The true names:** "Dömere" — spoken aloud at the standing stone. The spirit must hear it. It will respond.
- Soil from the pre-Saxon site:** The standing stone marks the original resting place before the Saxons built the church. Agents must dig a handful of soil from beneath the stone. The soil is darker, warmer than surrounding earth.
- A volunteer among the returned:** One of the 25 must willingly participate, speaking words of release from the Society's manual. This ends their borrowed existence. The volunteer must understand what they're

choosing. Margaret Hale (NPC5) is the intended volunteer — a former schoolteacher who has pieced together what she is.

If all three are present, the ritual forces the spirit into dormancy. The remaining 24 returned collapse and wake as themselves. The standing stone cools. The well goes silent. The compact is replaced by a binding — and the binding will hold as long as the stone remains undisturbed.